NORETHISTERONE

Period delay
VTE (high dose)

CHEMICAL NAME 17-hydroxy-19-nor-17α-pregn-4-en-20-yn-3-one (norethindrone)
CLASS Progestogen (19-nortestosterone derivative)
TRADE NAMES Primolut N · Utovlan · Noriday (POP) · Aygestin

THERAPEUTIC USES / INDICATIONS

- Heavy or irregular menstrual bleeding (acute control).
- Postponement of menstruation (travel, events).
- Endometriosis, dysmenorrhoea, premenstrual syndrome.
- Progestogen-only contraceptive pill (0.35 mg).

ADMINISTRATION

- **PO** at regular times.
- Period delay: start 3 days before expected period.

DOSAGES

- **Delay period:** 5 mg three times daily starting 3 days before the expected period; period usually follows within 3 days of stopping.
- **Heavy bleeding (acute):** 5 mg three times daily for 10 days.
- **Endometriosis:** 5 mg three times daily for at least 6 months (20–25 mg daily if spotting).
- **POP (Noriday 350 mcg):** 1 tablet daily at the same time, no break; missed if more than 3 h late.

PHARMACOKINETICS

- **Peak:** 1–2 h. Bioavailability ~64%.
- Partly converted to ethinylestradiol (oestrogenic effects at high dose).
- Metabolised in liver. **t½:** 8 h.

PHARMACODYNAMICS

- **Progestogen** → secretory endometrium, stabilises lining; high doses suppress ovulation.
- Weak androgenic and oestrogenic activity.

SIDE & ADVERSE EFFECTS

SIDE EFFECTS (COMMON)

- Bloating, breast tenderness, nausea.
- Mood change, headache.
- Acne, weight gain.

ADVERSE EFFECTS (SERIOUS)

- VTE at high doses (converted to EE); avoid in high VTE risk.
- Cholestatic jaundice.
- Virilisation of female fetus if taken in pregnancy.

CONTRAINDICATIONS & CAUTIONS

- Pregnancy.
- History of VTE or arterial disease (high-dose regimens).
- Severe liver disease; undiagnosed vaginal bleeding; breast cancer.
- Porphyria.

KEY INTERACTIONS

- **Enzyme inducers:** ↓ efficacy (contraceptive failure).

NURSING MANAGEMENT

- Check VTE risk factors before high-dose use.
- Exclude pregnancy.
- Assess bleeding pattern, Hb.
- POP: counsel on 3-h window.

PATIENT EDUCATION

- To delay a period, start 3 days before it is due; period follows 2–3 days after stopping.
- Not a reliable contraceptive at period-delay doses — use condoms.
- Report leg pain/swelling, chest pain or breathlessness.

KEY POINTS

- Progestogen for heavy bleeding and period delay.
- VTE at high doses (partly converted to EE).
- 5 mg TDS.
- Avoid in pregnancy.

SOURCES CHECKED **[685]** Noriday 350 microgram Tablets (UK SmPC) **[686]** Norethisterone 5mg Tablets (UK SmPC)
Full references p. 432–457